2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Antonio Cocone

Grade / Grado 8th

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Antonio Cocone

School / Escuela Rachel carson

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

My dad is a very amazing person, both as a father, son, brother, and uncle to everyone. He immigrated into the U.S for a better life for himself and for his future children, Three traits that brought him a life of success was his grit, his passion for his work, and his sense of responsibility when it comes to any challenge.

One trait that brought him to success was his grit, even in the moments where it felt like despair, he still rose and was able to overcome the challenges. One time where I saw him show his grit was when I was in 5th grade where he was constantly in distress about having too much taxes and not being able to pay them off on time. Later on in my life as I continued to go to school, he continued to work hard to pay them off and all the bills. Even in his hardest times, he still found a way to pay off the bills and was able to overcome his challenging time with nothing but grit and his determination.

Another trait that brought his success was his passion for his work. He always had a passion for his work even when my brothers were growing up and I wasn ' t born yet. One memory I have of my father was when I was in 4th grade were he would always come home tired and tired but he still woke up at 3 to get to work and still was able to go to work and work and work without any breaks in order to get the money and to be able to work for a better life for himself, my mother, my siblings, and me. That shows his passion for his work and for a better life for him and himself.

A third and final trait that my father has is his sense of responsibility to help others and for himself too. One day during summer break, he was still working and he got a call for church and a brother had recently gotten an injury and was not able to be a captain for the route, so my father took the responsibility and led the route with responsibility and everything was in order.

In conclusion, my father is a responsible man, and I'm lucky to have a father figure that has grit, a passion for his work, and sense of responsibility as most others don't have the same father figure.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.